

MGT477R: Consumer Behavior

SPRING 2026 (March 25, 2026 – June 12, 2026)

COURSE INFORMATION

PROFESSOR	Wendy Liu
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OFFICE HOURS	By appointment
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TEACHING ASSISTANT
TA EMAIL

This course runs on the Executive MBA schedule. It meets in-person 3 Weeks over the quarter (see exact dates below), and runs online the rest of the weeks asynchronously, with coordinated interactions with teams and the professor (see schedule below).

Meeting times for EMBA Sunday section:

- Sunday 4/12 8 am – 12 pm
- Sunday 5/10 8 am – 12 pm
- Sunday 6/7 8 am – 12 pm

DESCRIPTION

Contemporary approaches to business emphasize the importance of adopting a marketing focus (a.k.a. market demand focus) in which customer insight becomes a leading driver of business strategy. The primary goal of this course is to provide the framework, methodology and knowledge to help you effectively gain customer insight. We train you to think about customer behavior in a disciplined, strategic manner, and connect insight to marketing implementation. In addition, while we will not cover the mathematical mechanics of marketing research, we focus on the high-level understanding of marketing research to help you design and interpret research. You are very likely to be either the designers or clients of marketing research. Being able to ask the right questions and interpret the results in an insightful manner will greatly help the usefulness and impact of marketing research.

This course will include 3 weeks of in-person sessions, plus online asynchronous materials the rest of the time. Materials in-person and online will include case discussions, lectures, individual and group activities to practice what we have learned. Group projects will require coordination among teammates during the asynchronous weeks. Every session requires student input, so it is important that you prepare for class and participate in class activities as instructed.

In-person attendance is required for the in-person sessions. Online attendance is required for the asynchronous material.

OBJECTIVES

At the close of this course, you will be able to:

- Become demand-centric and audience-centric in business strategy
- Develop insight into consumer and client behavior
- Think like a “scientist of people” when approaching marketing challenges
- Use the customer insight framework to breakdown levels of insight needed
- Use behavioral insights to inform marketing strategy and practice
- Know how to seek, design, conduct and interpret marketing research for insight (for more technical knowledge, refer to courses on marketing research and data analytics)

MATERIALS

- Course Reader (cases, articles): These readings are required when assigned.
- Required Book Chapters: A few chapters will be assigned, and reading of them is required. You can read the rest of the chapters at your own pace, and there is no need to finish by the end of the quarter.
- Required Books:
 - Crossing the Chasm: Marketing and Selling Disruptive Products to Mainstream Customers
 - Thinking, Fast and Slow
 - Nudge: The Final Edition

ASSIGNMENTS

- Homework Assignments: Group and Individual Assignments
- Exams: No Midterm; No Final Exam

GRADING

Assignments	# of Assignments	Point Value
Class Participation (Online)	N/A	20%
Class Participation (In-Person)	N/A	10%
Individual Assignments (3)	3	15% + 2% + 8%
Group Assignments (3)	3	15% + 15% + 15%
Total		100

SCHEDULES

Module	Date	Meet*	Topics	Readings	Assignment (Due Date)**
Module 0: Orientation	03/25- 04/05	Online	- Course Introduction; - Course Orientation		REQUIRED: UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship (Due: 4/4; 11:59pm)
Module 1: Introduction	04/06 -04/12	In-Person (4/12; 8am -12pm)	- Intro to Customer Insight; - Qualitative Methods; - Course Frameworks; - Guest Speaker	- Case for Brand Loyalty (REQUIRED Case) - Headspace vs. Calm: A Mindful Competition (OPTIONAL Case)	
Module 2: Connecting with Culture	04/13- 04/19	Online	Connecting with Culture and Lifestyle	Nestl KITKAT in Japan (A): Sparking a Cultural Revolution (REQUIRED Case)	Individual Assignment : Creating a Product of Cultural Connection: Part 1 (Due: 4/26; 11:59pm)
Module 3: Connecting with Lifestage and Lifestyle	04/20 -04/26	Online	Connecting with Lifestage and Time	EILEEN FISHER: Repositioning the Brand (REQUIRED Case)	Individual Assignment: Creating a Product of Cultural Connection: Part 2 (Due: 5/03; 11:59pm)
Module 4: Connecting with Need and Behavior	04/27 -05/03	Online	Connecting with Need and Behavior		Group Assignment: NBS Questionnaire Design (Due: 5/17; 11:59pm)
Module 5: Macro to micro transition and Customer Journey	05/04 -05/10	In-Person (5/10; 8am -12pm)	- Connecting with Customer Journey and Goals; - Guest Speaker	- Away: Scaling a DTC Travel Brand (REQUIRED Case) - Othellonia: Growing a Mobile Game (OPTIONAL Case)	
Module 6: Connecting with Innovation	05/11- 05/17	Online	Connecting Customers to Innovation	- Arrive Mobility: Driving Innovation in the Parking Business (REQUIRED Case) - Crossing the Chasm: Part 1: Discovering the Chasm; the rest is optional (REQUIRED Book)	Group Project: Improving Adoption of New Product Part 1 (Due: 5/24; 11:59pm)
Module 7: Connecting	05/18- 05/24	Online	Connecting through Information	Thinking Fast and Slow (OPTIONAL Book)	Group Project: Battle of the Waterbottles (Due: 5/31; 11:59pm)

through Information					▪ Group Project: Battle of the Waterbottles - Voting (Due: 6/03; 11:59pm)
Module 8: Connecting through Information (cont'd)	05/25-05/31	Online	▪ Connecting through Information (continued)	▪ Avocados from Mexico: Success in an Omnichannel World (REQUIRED Case)	▪ Individual Assignment: Medium of Deep Deliberation (Due: 6/03; 11:59pm)
Module 9: Final Presentation and Discussion	06/1-06/07	In-Person (6/07; 8am -12pm)	▪ Final Presentations; ▪ Discussions; ▪ Guest Speaker		▪ Group Project: Improving Adoption of New Product Part 2 (Due: Final Presentation on 6/07)
Quarter Ends	6/12	Online			

*In-person (Location: **OTRSN 1E106**) and Online (Canvas and Office Hours)

**All assignments/assessments are due by 11:59 p.m. Pacific Time on the due date.

Disclaimer: Please note that the specifics of this Course Syllabus are subject to change, and you will be responsible for abiding by any such changes. Your instructor will notify you of any changes.

Canvas Technical Specifications

Operating System	Penn State's LMS, Canvas, supports most recent versions of Microsoft Windows and Apple Mac operating systems. To determine if your operating system is supported, please review the Canvas Computer Specifications .
Hardware	For a list of required computer hardware specifications and internet speed, please review the Canvas Computer Specifications .
Browser	Canvas supports the last two versions of every major browser release. We highly recommend updating to the newest version of whatever browser you are using. To determine if your browser is supported, please review the list of Canvas Supported Browsers. Please note that due to Instructure's reduction of support for Internet Explorer, students and instructors should choose another browser to use such as Firefox, Chrome, Edge, or Safari.
	Note: Cookies must be enabled, and pop-up blockers should be configured to permit new windows from Penn State websites.
Sound Card, Microphone, and Speakers	Required
Monitor	Capable of at least 1024 x 768 resolution
Mobile Device	The Canvas mobile app is available for versions of iOS and Android. To determine if your device is capable of using the Canvas Mobile App, please review the Canvas Mobile App Requirements .

COURSE POLICIES

- Attendance for in-person session is required and counts towards participation grade. Absence of 1 in-person session is allowed without penalty for sickness and severe conflicts. Class participation for asynchronous sessions will be tracked and count towards participation grade.
- Generative AI use is allowed.
 - For assignments that do not specify how AI can be used, you may use Generative AI in any way you see fit, while keeping in mind that AI may not give the best answers, and accepting AI answers without critical thinking and editing may lead to worse work than not using AI. You will need to use your judgment based on your learnings in the course to incorporate AI into your work. To help everyone understand the role of AI in marketing functions, I encourage you to disclose all usage of AI in your work (it will not affect your grade either way, but it will be helpful learning for the class in terms of what AI can do).
 - Further, for some assignments, you will be explicitly asked to come up with two sets of answers: (a) Answers that AI generates for you, and (b) using non-AI methods to come up with answers; and you will be asked to compare the difference between the two sets of answers.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at: <http://www-senate.ucsd.edu/manual/appendices/app2.htm#AP14>

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with

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Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.

Please visit the OSD website for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.